the military balance between the two sides and on the war aims of the Arabs.

The military balance

Key question
Which side had the stronger military forces?

The Zionist version of history maintains that the Arab forces always had far larger numbers of troops and of weapons. It is certainly true that, at the start of the war, the Israelis only had about 30,000 soldiers and that their weapons were inferior. But they built up the army to about 65,000 by July and had nearly 100,000 in arms by December 1948. The total number of Arab troops involved in the fighting was similar at the start and was also built up during the war but not as fast as that of the Israelis. With regard to weaponry, the Israelis were poorly equipped at the start but, particularly during the first truce in June–July 1948, they gained access to much more equipment from Europe and thus were better armed for the rest of the war. In short, the stronger side won.

The Israelis also had other military advantages. About 25,000 Israelis had fought in the British army in the Second World War and gained valuable experience in training, organisation and technology. The only Arab force that was as well trained and disciplined was the 10,000 of the Arab Legion of Transjordan (which was partly financed by Britain and was led by British officers).

War aims

The Jews in Palestine, particularly under the leadership of Ben-Gurion, had recognised, for several years, that they would need to use force to establish their new state. In this, they were united. The Palestinian Arabs, on the other hand, lacked strong, united leadership. They were let down by their leaders, many of whom had left Palestine in the final days of the British mandate. The governments of the neighbouring Arab states had begun to plan for invasion only in April 1948. They had agreed on a plan and King Abdullah of Transjordan claimed to be commander-in-chief. But the Arab leaders were not united in their goals and each tended to fight for their own particular interests, which often meant to gain control of a piece of Palestinian territory for themselves. There was very little co-ordination of their efforts in the war and both the Egyptian and Syrian governments were deeply suspicious of King Abdullah's aims.

King Abdullah and the Israelis

Key question
What were the war aims of King Abdullah of Jordan?

The case of King Abdullah of Transjordan is particularly significant. Before the war he had held a secret meeting with one of the Israeli leaders. He had let it be known that he did not think the Palestinian Arab state could survive on its own. He thought it would be too weak and he wished to attach it to his state. He saw himself as the leader of an enlarged Arab state (and, in this, he had some support from the British). He also led Jewish leaders to believe that he would *not* invade territory allocated to